Student Outcomes and Academic Support Priorities

OULAD Project | Executive report for stakeholders | October 2026

Reducing withdrawal and monitoring assessment completion alongside platform engagement should be the main priorities. The updated findings show that high engagement is less strongly associated with success when submission is low. Higher study loads and previous attempts are also associated with weaker outcomes. These patterns can guide support allocation, but do not establish the causes of difficulty or the effectiveness of any intervention.

Study scope and overall outcomes

The study covers 32,593 enrollments by 28,785 students across 7 modules and 22 presentations in 2013 and 2014. The unit of analysis is a student enrollment in a module presentation, not a unique student. Overall success includes both PASS and DISTINCTION ;distinction must not be added to it again.

Outcome	Enrollments	Rate
Success	15,385	47.20%
Withdrawn	10,156	31.16%
Fail	7,052	21.64%
Distinction included in Success	3,024	9.28%

Module and presentation priorities

Priorities depend on both the rate of weaker outcomes and the number of cases. CCC has the highest withdrawal rate, while FFF and BBB require substantial support capacity because of their case volumes. GGG needs a focus on academic performance despite its low withdrawal rate.

Module	Key finding	Enrollments affected
CCC	Withdrawal 44.54%	1,975 withdrawals
DDD	Withdrawal 35.87%	2,250 withdrawals
FFF	Withdrawal 30.96%	2,403 withdrawals
BBB	Withdrawal 30.19%	2,388 withdrawals
GGG	Failure 28.73%	728 failures

Withdrawal reached 46.38% in CCC 2014B. CCC 2014J had 1,077 withdrawals, the largest count of any presentation. In all nine available comparisons holding module and presentation term constant, withdrawal was higher in 2014 than in 2013 ;GGG J had the largest increase, at 9.89 percentage points. Term J had higher success in 8 of 9 comparisons with B and lower failure in all nine, but no consistent reduction in withdrawal. A year comparison is unavailable for CCC.

Support before and throughout the course

There were 2,676 withdrawals before the course started, or 8.21% of all enrollments, and another 2,356 during days 0–27. Together these account for 49.55% of withdrawals. The first four weeks withdrawal rate among enrollments with known eligibility at the start was 7.92%. These findings support early onboarding and continued follow-up after the first month, when approximately half of withdrawals occurred.

Study load and previous attempts

Higher studied credits were associated with lower success and higher withdrawal. Withdrawal increased across workload bands within all seven modules. Comparing 1–60 credits with more than 120 credits, it rose from 37.22% to 62.84% in CCC and from 28.59% to 60.08% in DDD. Academic advising should therefore review whether study load fits each student's available time and capacity.

Workload band	Enrollments	Success	Withdrawn
1–60 credits	20,568	51.80%	25.35%
61–120 credits	9,769	41.42%	38.75%
<120 credits	2,256	30.36%	51.29%

Among the 4,172 enrollments with previous attempts, success was 33.08%, versus 49.28% without previous attempts. Failure was 31.66% versus 20.16%, and withdrawal was 35.26% versus 30.56%. These differences support a follow-up plan for students repeating a module, beyond simply allowing re-enrollment.

Engagement and submission together

In the joint comparison for the first four weeks, success was 69.35% when both engagement and submission were high, versus 22.82% with high engagement and low submission. It was 50.27% with low engagement and high submission, and 10.83% when both were low. Submission monitoring therefore provides useful additional information when identifying support needs.

Early engagement / submission	Enrollments	Success	Withdrawn
High / High	10,567	69.35%	15.08%
High / Low	241	22.82%	41.49%
Low / High	8,730	50.27%	20.27%
Low / Low	1,995	10.83%	40.90%

This comparison covers 21,533 enrollments in AAA, BBB, CCC, DDD and FFF ;it excludes EEE and GGG. High engagement means positive clicks at or above the presentation median within the comparison sample. High submission means completing at least 80% of assessments due in the window by day 27. These are exploratory descriptive thresholds. The high engagement / low submission group contains only 241 enrollments, limiting the precision of comparisons with larger groups.

Assessment gaps require direct follow-up

Of 214,627 eligible current TMA and CMA assessment opportunities, excluding banked assessments, 22.93% had no submission record. Of submissions with usable timing, 29.64% were late ;median delay was 3 days. Mean submission completion per enrollment was 96.68% for distinction, 95.52% for pass, 43.67% for fail and 58.17% for withdrawal. Mean enrollment scores where scores were available were 88.39, 76.50, 64.32 and 63.66, respectively ;assessment weights were not applied.

Median early active days were 14 for distinction, 11 for pass, 7 for fail and 8 for withdrawal. The presence of engagement alone remains insufficient :93.38% of failed enrollments recorded clicks from the course start onward.

Targeting support and measuring improvement

We propose a limited support pilot, evaluated before expansion. Prioritize cases using combined indicators of difficulty, with human review of the data and student circumstances. Measure outcomes within the same module and presentation to reduce differences in enrollment composition.

Proposed stakeholder actions

1. Module leaders and student services :prioritize understanding withdrawal in CCC and DDD, investigate increases in 2014 presentations, and allocate capacity for the case volumes in FFF and BBB. Track both withdrawal rates and counts for each presentation.

2. Academic advisers :review study load, particularly above 120 credits, and provide a follow-up plan for enrollments with previous attempts. Address requirements, study time and referrals to suitable support. Evaluate continuation and final success.

3. Teaching teams :follow up missing expected submissions and low scores, including among highly engaged students. Check record completeness and due dates before contacting students. Prioritize remedial support and assessment completion in GGG ;track submission and failure rates.

4. Technical support and student services :begin onboarding and access checks before day 0 and provide practical help during the first four weeks. Monitor active days, engagement changes and assessments due, while distinguishing absent records from confirmed inactivity.

Access to support for groups with weaker outcomes

Withdrawal was 39.35% among students with a recorded disability versus 30.28% among others ;37.18% in the most deprived 0–10% band versus 25.87% in the 90–100% band ;and 42.94% among those with no formal qualifications versus 28.69% with A Level or equivalent. It was 32.17% in the 0–35 age band versus 28.85% in the 35–55 band. These differences warrant reviewing accessibility and academic preparation, without inferring an individual’s needs solely from group characteristics.

By region, withdrawal was 35.58% in North Western Region, while failure was 29.72% in Wales. Comparisons remain subject to module differences and missing data :deprivation band was unavailable for 1,111 enrollments, with missingness concentrated in some regions.

Learning resources and follow-up measures

During days 0–27, FORUMNG accounted for 26.12% of clicks, OUCONTENT 20.78%, HOMEPAGE 19.01% and QUIZ 15.46%. FORUMNG’s share was higher among successful enrollments, but usage volume does not establish learning quality or resource effectiveness. Test assessment-related discussions and easier access to content, then monitor submission and final outcomes.

Interpretation and evaluation requirements

This historical descriptive analysis establishes neither causality nor a validated alert model. Final outcomes are known after enrollment ends ;future interventions must use only information available at the time. The days 0–27 comparison excludes students who withdrew before completing the window, and engagement statistics exclude 475 eligible enrollments without records. Weekly eligibility changes over time, so group lines do not track a fixed set of individuals.

Evaluate support using comparable groups, preferably randomized where feasible, accounting for module, presentation, study load and previous attempts. Report outcome rates, case counts and uncertainty, and review alert rules before adoption. Source :saved outputs in Final_OULAD_Analysis(3).ipynb. The appendix provides supporting charts and denominator definitions.